Although the cadre of the left parties did not actively participate in the Yatra, many supporters of the left did join the crowds, cheering for Rahul Gandhi and the yatris.

In response to a question from a media representative about my left-leaning inclinations and why I chose to walk with Rahul Gandhi, my response was clear, ‘Rahul Gandhi is walking across India for all of us. Beyond all political ideologies, we can all agree on what the BJY stands for. We should walk with him. I believe the left parties should walk with him. Sitaram Yechury and Pinarayi Vijayan should walk with him. I am glad the walk was flagged off with M.K. Stalin walking with him. I believe anyone fighting against fascism should walk with him. It’s not just a one-day protest or a dharna. It’s a journey across the country, covering 4,000 kilometres. It’s a penance, a satyagraha, of the most powerful kind.’

Ideally, the CPI(M) should have joined this movement, but regrettably, Kerala’s CPI(M) faction remained an immovable block. This was a missed opportunity for the left parties to align with a movement that resonated with the spirit of unity and diversity that defines India’s essence.

## Rahul Redefines Politics

In recent years, politics has shifted from the streets to the media and public relations (PR) agencies, particularly after Narendra Modi became the Prime Minister. Rahul Gandhi, through the BJY, has brought the conversations back to the streets and villages, engaging with various sections of society. Politics in India is slowly transforming, shifting from being PR-centric to the grassroots. It’s a cyclical return to Gandhian non-violent, disciplined satyagraha-inspired struggle. The Bharat Jodo Yatra resonates with the spirit of the Dandi March and successful marches such as Yeduguri Sandinti Rajasekhara Reddy’s that brought him back to power. Walking, or a padyatra, is a tool close to the heart of the Congress, reminding us of the overwhelming power of direct connection with the people.